Social Psychology

How other people change what we think and do — conformity, obedience, persuasion, attribution, prejudice and helping — and how each shows up in meetings, sales and teams.

Isagi · November 2026 · Spine: Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology* (4th ed.), Ch. 12 — rewritten, updated and applied

Social psychology studies how people's thoughts, feelings and behaviour are shaped by the real or imagined presence of others. It is the part of psychology with the biggest payoff for a manager, because almost everything a manager does happens through other people: persuading a dealer, running a meeting, judging why a rep missed target, building a team that doesn't freeze when something goes wrong. It is also the part hit hardest by the replication crisis (Part 0), so every claim here comes with its evidence status.

1 Conformity and groups

Conformity is changing your behaviour to match a group. In Solomon Asch's 1951 studies, a participant sat with a group asked to say which of three lines matched a reference line — an easy task, with near-perfect accuracy alone. But the others were actors who, on certain trials, unanimously gave the wrong answer. Across those trials, participants went along with the group about a third of the time, and roughly three-quarters conformed at least once. When just one other person gave the right answer, conformity dropped sharply.

People conform for two reasons: **informational** (the group may know something you don't) and **normative** (wanting to be accepted). Conformity tends to be higher in more collectivist cultures. The lesson about the lone ally is the most useful: a single dissenting voice frees others to speak.

Groupthink and polarisation

Groupthink (Irving Janis, 1972) is a group's tendency to value agreement over good decisions. Its warning signs: an illusion of invulnerability, dismissing warnings, pressure on dissenters, self-censorship, and an illusion that everyone agrees. It is most likely in close-knit groups with a directive leader under time pressure. **Group polarisation** is related: after discussion, groups tend to take a more extreme position in the direction they already leaned. A cautious team becomes more cautious; a bullish one more bullish.

Remedies: the leader speaks last; someone is assigned to argue against the plan; people write down their views before discussion; outsiders review big decisions.

Facilitation and loafing

The presence of others raises arousal. **Social facilitation**: we perform simple, well-practised tasks better with an audience, and complex or new tasks worse — Yerkes–Dodson again (Part 8). **Social loafing**: people put in less effort in a group when individual contributions aren't identifiable. In the 1880s Max Ringelmann found that people pulling on a rope together pulled less hard per person as the group grew; later studies with clapping and shouting found the same.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 · PRICING SOCIAL LOAFING

Eight reps share a single team target with a shared bonus. Working alone, each would average ₹50 lakh a year. Suppose loafing cuts average effort by 20% when output isn't tracked individually (illustrative).

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Potential:      8 × ₹50 lakh       = ₹400 lakh
With loafing:   8 × ₹50 × 0.80     = ₹320 lakh
Lost to loafing                    = ₹80 lakh
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The fix is not to abolish team targets — they help cooperation — but to make each contribution visible: individual dashboards alongside the team number, clear ownership of accounts, and recognition that names people. Loafing shrinks when people believe their effort is identifiable and matters.

2 Compliance: getting a yes

Compliance is changing behaviour in response to a direct request. Several techniques are well documented — and widely used in sales:

- **Foot-in-the-door** — a small request first makes a larger one more likely. In a 1966 study by Jonathan Freedman and Scott Fraser, homeowners asked to put a large, ugly "Drive Carefully" sign in their garden mostly refused (about 17% agreed). But among those who had, two weeks earlier, agreed to display a tiny sign, about 76% agreed.
- **Door-in-the-face** — a large request that's refused makes a smaller follow-up more likely, because the requester appears to have conceded. In a 1975 study, students asked to chaperone young offenders to a zoo for a day agreed about 17% of the time; asked first to mentor them for two years (refused), about half then agreed to the zoo trip.
- **Lowball** — get agreement, then raise the cost. People tend to stick with commitments even when the terms worsen.
- **That's-not-all** — add a bonus before the person has answered.

Robert Cialdini's book *Influence* (1984) grouped these into six principles: **reciprocity** (we return favours), **commitment and consistency** (we act in line with what we've already said or done), **social proof** (we follow what others like us do), **authority**, **liking** (we say yes to people we like and who are like us), and **scarcity** (we want what's limited).

A line to hold: these principles describe real tendencies, so they can be used honestly (showing genuine testimonials from nearby dealers, offering a real limited-period scheme) or manipulatively (fake scarcity, lowballing a dealer on credit terms). The manipulative uses work once and destroy the relationship that repeat business depends on.

3 Obedience

Obedience is following the orders of an authority. In Stanley Milgram's 1963 study, 40 men were told they were helping study learning by giving a "learner" (an actor) electric shocks of increasing strength for wrong answers. As the learner protested, then screamed, then fell silent, an experimenter in a grey coat said "please continue". In the best-known version, 26 of 40 — 65% — went all the way to the maximum 450 volts. No shocks were real.

Variations showed what drives it. Obedience fell when the learner was in the same room, when the experimenter gave orders by phone, and dramatically when two other "teachers" refused. A partial replication by Jerry Burger in 2009, stopping at 150 volts for ethical reasons, found about 70% willing to continue past that point, close to Milgram's rate. Historians who studied Milgram's archives have raised real concerns — some participants doubted the set-up, and procedures varied more than reported — but the core finding that ordinary people defer heavily to authority has held.

The organisational lesson: when a senior person pushes, juniors comply with things they know are wrong — loading stock, misreporting, skipping safety steps — especially when the authority is close and dissent is isolated. Make dissent easy and safe, and make it normal for someone to say "no".

4 Attitudes and persuasion

An **attitude** is an evaluation of a person, object or idea, with three components: **affective** (feelings), **behavioural** (tendencies to act) and **cognitive** (beliefs). Attitudes predict behaviour better when they are strong, specific and personally relevant.

Two routes to persuasion

Richard Petty and John Cacioppo's **elaboration likelihood model** says persuasion travels two routes. On the **central route**, people think carefully about the arguments; strong arguments persuade and weak ones backfire. On the **peripheral route**, people respond to cues — the speaker's attractiveness or status, the number of arguments, the mood. Which route people take depends on their motivation and ability to think about the message. A contractor choosing paint for a ₹40 lakh hotel project is on the central route: give him data on coverage, durability and lifetime cost. A homeowner glancing at a hoarding is on the peripheral route: celebrity, colour and repetition do the work. Central-route persuasion takes more effort but produces attitudes that last and resist counter-arguments.

Cognitive dissonance

Leon Festinger proposed that holding inconsistent beliefs, or acting against one's beliefs, creates discomfort — **cognitive dissonance** — that people reduce by changing a belief. In a 1959 study, students did a boring task and were then paid either $1 or $20 to tell the next participant it was fun. The $1 group later rated the task as more enjoyable. With $20, the lie was explained by the money; with $1, the only way to reduce dissonance was to believe the task was not so bad. Small incentives can change attitudes more than large ones.

The everyday business version is **post-purchase dissonance**: after a big purchase, customers worry they chose wrong. Reassurance — a follow-up call, a thank-you note listing what they got — reduces it and protects repeat business.

5 Judging others: attribution

We constantly explain other people's behaviour. **Attribution theory** distinguishes **internal** (dispositional) explanations — something about the person — from **external** (situational) ones — something about the circumstances. The most important finding is the **fundamental attribution error**: when judging others, we overweight personality and underweight the situation. In a 1967 study, people read essays they knew had been assigned to writers, yet still judged the writers as believing what they'd written.

When judging ourselves we do the opposite. The **actor–observer bias**: I missed target because of the monsoon; you missed it because you're lazy. And the **self-serving bias**: successes are mine, failures are bad luck. In reviews, this is the mistake that does the most damage. Before concluding that a rep is the problem, check his territory, stock availability, competitor activity and dealer mix — and compare him with others facing the same conditions.

First impressions form within seconds and are sticky, through the primacy effect (Part 5) and confirmation bias (Part 6). **Stereotypes** — generalised beliefs about members of a group — are efficient shortcuts that become harmful when applied to individuals.

6 Prejudice and how to reduce it

Prejudice is a negative attitude toward people based on group membership; **discrimination** is acting on it. Henri Tajfel's **minimal group** experiments showed how little it takes: boys divided into groups on a trivial basis, such as preferring one painter over another, favoured their own group when sharing out rewards. **Social identity theory** explains this: our self-esteem is tied to groups we belong to, so we favour the **in-group**. In Muzafer Sherif's 1954 **Robbers Cave** study, two groups of boys at a summer camp became hostile when made to compete for prizes, and hostility eased when they had to cooperate on shared goals, such as fixing the camp's water supply. (Later analysis showed the researchers shaped events more than the original report admitted, but the pattern has support elsewhere.)

The best-supported remedy is **intergroup contact**. A 2006 meta-analysis of over 500 studies by Thomas Pettigrew and Linda Tropp found that contact between groups reliably reduces prejudice, especially with equal status, shared goals, cooperation and support from leaders. Elliot Aronson's **jigsaw classroom**, where each student holds a piece of information the group needs, applies the same idea. For a company merging two sales forces, or mixing head-office and field staff, the design is clear: mixed teams, a common target, equal status within the team, and visible backing from leadership.

7 Liking

We like people we see often (**proximity** and the **mere-exposure effect**: familiarity breeds liking), people similar to us, people who like us back (**reciprocity of liking**), and — unfairly — attractive people. These are the mechanics of the "relationship" in relationship selling: regular visits, finding common ground and showing genuine interest in the dealer. They work because they are real, which is also why they can't be faked for long.

8 Helping and the bystander effect

In 1964 Kitty Genovese was murdered in New York, and a newspaper reported that 38 neighbours watched and did nothing. The story prompted John Darley and Bibb Latané's research on the **bystander effect**: the more people present, the less likely any one of them is to help. In their 1968 study, a participant heard another student apparently having a seizure over an intercom. When participants believed they were the only listener, about 85% went to help before the fit ended; when they believed four others were also listening, only about 31% did. The main cause is **diffusion of responsibility**: everyone assumes someone else will act.

Two corrections. The Genovese story was badly exaggerated: far fewer people saw the attack, and at least one called the police; the newspaper later acknowledged the errors. And a 2020 study of CCTV footage of real public conflicts in three countries found that in about 9 of 10 cases at

least one bystander intervened — and that more bystanders made intervention *more* likely, since it only takes one. The lab effect is real for each individual; in real groups, someone usually acts.

Diffusion of responsibility is common in organisations: a problem flagged in a group email of twenty people that nobody owns. Name an owner, not a group.

9 Held up?

Finding	Verdict	Why
Asch conformity	**Holds**	Replicated many times, though rates vary by era and culture.
Milgram obedience	**Mostly**	Partial replication at similar rates; archival critiques about procedure and belief.
Foot-in-the-door, door-in-the-face	**Hold, modest**	Meta-analyses find reliable but smaller effects than the classic studies.
Cognitive dissonance	**Mostly**	A core finding; some classic paradigms have replicated weakly.
Intergroup contact reduces prejudice	**Strong**	Hundreds of studies; strongest under the right conditions.
Bystanders don't help	**Lab yes, life less so**	Individual likelihood drops in groups, but in real conflicts someone usually intervenes.
The Implicit Association Test reveals who will discriminate	**Weak**	IAT scores predict individual behaviour poorly and are unstable on retest.

Summary

- **Conformity**: in Asch's studies, people went along with a wrong majority about a third of the time; one ally sharply reduced it.
- **Groupthink** and **polarisation** distort group decisions; the leader speaking last and an assigned dissenter help. **Social loafing** shrinks when individual effort is visible.
- **Compliance**: foot-in-the-door, door-in-the-face, lowball; Cialdini's six principles. Honest use builds relationships, manipulation burns them.
- **Obedience**: 65% went to the maximum in Milgram's study; it falls when authority is distant and others refuse. Make dissent safe.
- **Persuasion**: central route (arguments) for engaged audiences, peripheral route (cues) for disengaged ones. **Cognitive dissonance** changes attitudes; reassure customers after big purchases.
- **Attribution**: the fundamental attribution error overweights personality. Check the situation before blaming the person.
- **Prejudice** arises easily from group identity; contact with equal status and shared goals reduces it.
- Liking grows with proximity, similarity and reciprocity.
- **Bystander effect**: diffusion of responsibility lowers individual helping — name an owner. In real-world conflicts, someone usually helps.

Practice problems

P1. Ten reps share a team bonus. Each would sell ₹40 lakh alone; loafing cuts effort by 15%. How much output is lost? Suggest two fixes.

P2. Name the technique: (a) asking a dealer to stock one trial SKU, then the full range a month later; (b) proposing an exclusive 3-year deal, then settling for a 6-month display agreement; (c) agreeing a price, then adding freight charges at billing.

P3. A rep in a flood-hit district missed target by 30%. His manager writes "lacks drive" in the review. Which bias is this? What should the manager check?

P4. You're pitching a waterproofing system to a builder's procurement head, and separately running a TV ad for homeowners. Which persuasion route fits each, and what would you emphasise?

P5. The leadership team unanimously approves an aggressive launch in one 20-minute meeting where the CEO spoke first. What risk does this show? List three process changes.

P6. Two regional sales teams are being merged after an acquisition and there is open rivalry. Design a 90-day plan using the contact hypothesis.

Glossary

Conformity

Changing behaviour to match a group.

Informational / normative influence

Conforming because others may be right / to be accepted.

Groupthink

A group prizing agreement over good decisions.

Group polarisation

Groups becoming more extreme after discussion.

Social facilitation / loafing

Better simple performance with an audience / less effort in groups.

Compliance

Changing behaviour in response to a direct request.

Foot-in-the-door / door-in-the-face

Small request first / large refused request first.

Obedience

Following orders from an authority figure.

Elaboration likelihood model

Persuasion by careful thought (central) or by cues (peripheral).

Cognitive dissonance

Discomfort from inconsistent beliefs or actions, reduced by changing beliefs.

Fundamental attribution error

Overweighting personality, underweighting situation, when judging others.

Actor–observer / self-serving bias

Blaming situations for our own failures / taking credit for successes.

Social identity theory

Self-esteem tied to group membership drives in-group favouritism.

Contact hypothesis

Cooperative, equal-status contact between groups reduces prejudice.

Mere-exposure effect

Liking things more as they become familiar.

Diffusion of responsibility

Each person feeling less responsible when others are present.

Answer key

P1. Potential 10 × 40 = ₹400 lakh; actual 10 × 40 × 0.85 = ₹340 lakh; lost ₹60 lakh. Fixes: individual dashboards alongside the team number; named account ownership; recognition that names individuals.

P2. (a) foot-in-the-door; (b) door-in-the-face; (c) lowball — a manipulative use that damages trust.

P3. The fundamental attribution error. Check the flood's effect on demand and logistics, stock availability, and how other reps in affected districts performed.

P4. Procurement head: central route — technical data, warranty, lifetime cost, references. Homeowners: peripheral route — a trusted face, visual proof, repetition, simple message.

P5. Groupthink, amplified by the leader speaking first. Changes: leader speaks last; written views before discussion; an assigned devil's advocate or pre-mortem; a second meeting before final approval.

P6. Mixed pairs from both teams on joint accounts; one combined regional target with a shared bonus; equal titles and status within the merged team; leaders from both sides publicly backing the plan; early shared wins celebrated jointly.

Sources: chapter structure follows Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology*, 4th ed. (Pearson), Ch. 12; text and figures are original. Asch, 1951/1956. Janis, *Victims of Groupthink*, 1972. Freedman & Fraser, 1966. Cialdini et al., 1975; Cialdini, *Influence*, 1984. Milgram, 1963; Burger, *American Psychologist*, 2009. Festinger & Carlsmith, 1959. Petty & Cacioppo, 1986. Jones & Harris, 1967. Pettigrew & Tropp, *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 2006. Darley & Latané, 1968. Philpot et al., *American Psychologist*, 2020. IAT: Oswald et al., 2013. Worked-example figures are illustrative.